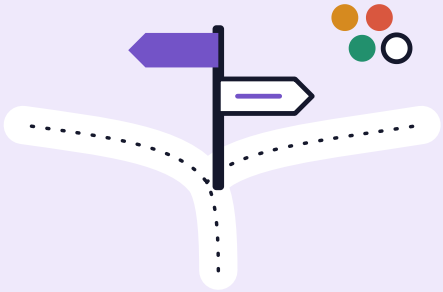
Conversation 4 · Decision making

How do we make decisions?

Clarity about autonomy, participation and accountability.



Key questions

1. Which decisions can individuals make?
2. Which decisions need input or shared ownership?
3. Which ways of deciding could we try?

The exercise

Choose how to decide

Whole team · 30 min

Pick one important decision you make often, and choose a way to make it next time.

Notes from the conversation

Goes on your Team Canvas: **Our decision making**

Choose how to decide

How do we make decisions? · Whole team · 30 min

Pick one important decision you make often, and choose a way to make it next time.

How to run it

1. Each person names decisions that come up again and again. Agree on one that matters to the team.
2. Read the twelve ways to decide together. Ask what this decision needs: narrowing options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say.
3. Choose one way and try it the next few times the decision comes up.
4. Talk about how it felt, and whether to keep it or try another.

Twelve ways to decide

Narrow down options

Dot voting A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.

Multi-voting One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.

Scoring matrix Every option has its own trade-offs.

Decide quickly

Majority vote There are two options and either would work.

Plurality There are several options and no time for more rounds.

Authority One person is accountable for the outcome.

Bring everyone along

Fist to five People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.

Consensus Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.

Consent You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

Settle who has the final say

Supermajority A big decision needs more than a narrow win.

Unanimity Every person must actively agree before you move.

Delegation The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

Worksheet

A decision we make often

The way we'll try to decide

Twelve ways to decide

Choose the way before the discussion starts. Ask what this decision needs most: narrowing many options, speed, everyone on board, or a clear final say. Then pick one way from that group and write it on the canvas.

Narrow down options

Dot voting

How it works: Everyone places a few dots in one round. Then talk about the options at the top.

Use it when: A long list of ideas needs a shortlist, fast.

Watch out: Popular isn't always right. Discuss the top options before you decide.

Multi-voting

How it works: Vote in rounds and drop the weakest option each time, until a shortlist remains.

Use it when: One round of votes is too scattered to show a favourite.

Watch out: It takes longer. Agree the number of rounds up front.

Scoring matrix

How it works: Rate each option against three to five agreed criteria, then compare totals and trade-offs.

Use it when: Every option has its own trade-offs.

Watch out: Agree the criteria before scoring, or people choose criteria that fit their favourite.

Decide quickly

Majority vote

How it works: One vote each. The option with more than half of the votes wins.

Use it when: There are two options and either would work.

Watch out: The losing side may not commit. Only use it when both options are acceptable.

Plurality

How it works: One vote each. The option with the most votes wins, even below half.

Use it when: There are several options and no time for more rounds.

Watch out: The winner may have less than half the room behind it.

Authority

How it works: One person hears from the people affected, then decides and explains why.

Use it when: One person is accountable for the outcome.

Watch out: Say up front that one person decides, and explain the decision afterwards.

Bring everyone along

Fist to five

How it works: Everyone shows zero to five fingers at the same time. Ask the lowest: what would raise your score by one?

Use it when: People seem to agree, but you can't tell if they really do.

Watch out: Low scores need a conversation, not a new vote.

Consensus

How it works: Share a proposal, listen to concerns, adapt it, and check that everyone can back it.

Use it when: Everyone needs to support the decision to carry it out.

Watch out: Slow, and the most cautious person can block. Save it for decisions everyone must carry.

Consent

How it works: Ask for serious reasons not to try it. Resolve the valid objections, then go ahead.

Use it when: You need to move on, even if it isn't everyone's first choice.

Watch out: An objection needs a reason, a risk or harm, not just a preference.

Settle who has the final say

Supermajority

How it works: Agree a threshold, such as 75%, before voting. Go ahead only if you reach it.

Use it when: A big decision needs more than a narrow win.

Watch out: Set the threshold before the vote, never after.

Unanimity

How it works: Each person gives a clear yes or no. A single no sends the proposal back.

Use it when: Every person must actively agree before you move.

Watch out: One person can stop everything. Use it rarely.

Delegation

How it works: Choose who decides, and agree their mandate, limits and deadline.

Use it when: The whole team doesn't need to weigh in every time.

Watch out: Write the mandate down, and don't overrule the person afterwards.

Combine them: narrow down with dot voting, then decide by consent. Whatever you choose, agree who decides, who is asked first, and who is told afterwards.

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